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MEDIA &
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Spotify raises subscription prices



Spotify [announced](#) on Monday that its premium subscription prices will increase for users in multiple markets across the Middle East, Africa, Europe, Latin America, and the Asia-Pacific region.

Over the next month, impacted subscribers will receive an email explaining that their monthly subscription cost will increase from €10,99 to €11,99.

Spotify made a similar [change](#) last year for users in the U.S., increasing prices from \$10.99 to \$11.99 — at the time, it marked the second instance when they had hiked prices over the last year.

These price hikes arrive after Spotify's rough earnings report last week, when the platform missed revenue expectations, causing its stock price to [drop](#) 11%. On the corresponding earnings call with investors, CEO Daniel Ek [stated](#) that he is "unhappy with where [Spotify is] today," but remained "confident in the ambitions we laid out for this business."

Spotify's [shares rose 5%](#) in premarket trading after announcing the price hikes.

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IMAGE CREDITS:

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Warner Music Group signs on to SoundCloud's artist-friendly payment model

Amanda Silberling — 6:01 AM PDT · July 21, 2022

When SoundCloud launched its artist-friendly [fan-powered royalty system](#) last year, the model was only available for independent artists subscribed to

the streamer’s paid tiers. Now, SoundCloud has inked its first major label partnership with Warner Music Group, whose artists can now earn fan-powered royalties on the platform too.

Since the early 2000s, artists and record labels alike have struggled to figure out how musicians can make a living when it’s so easy to download .mp3s online. New models like music streaming on Spotify can feel like a stop-gap, though, since payouts from these services can be [paltry](#) if you’re not Lizzo or Olivia Rodrigo.

Spotify pays artists via a pro-rata model, which means there is a large pot of money that gets divided among all artists depending on how many streams they each get. But that means that the success of superstar musicians can inadvertently take away from the payouts of up-and-coming performers.

The user-centric model, or what SoundCloud calls [fan-powered royalties](#) (FPR), is designed to level the playing field for smaller artists.

“Under FPR, each fan’s subscription or advertising revenue is distributed among the artists they listen to, rather than being pooled under the traditional pro-rata model the music industry has been using for over a decade,” SoundCloud explained in a press release.

In its initial roll-out of FPR, only independent artists were eligible to earn FPR, and they have to pay [at least \\$30 a year](#). Now that SoundCloud has signed a licensing deal with Warner Music Group (WMG), one of the largest global record companies, even more musicians will be eligible for these payouts from SoundCloud.

Getting signed to a major label is no easy feat, so the artists this deal will benefit are already pretty established. But affiliation with WMG doesn’t always

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guarantee riches, especially for artists whose revenue from touring has been decimated during the coronavirus pandemic.

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Buy-in from major labels is necessary for an FPR system to work, which is why Deezer hasn't been able to widely implement a similar model yet, despite [vocally advocating](#) for it since 2019.

Meanwhile, Tidal introduced a fan-centric model in November that doesn't require buy-in from labels. In addition to standard pro-rata payouts, fans on

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Tidal's highest tier (\$20 per month) will see 10% of their monthly payment sent straight to their most-listened-to artist. Tidal only makes up a [small fraction](#) of the global streaming music subscription market, though.

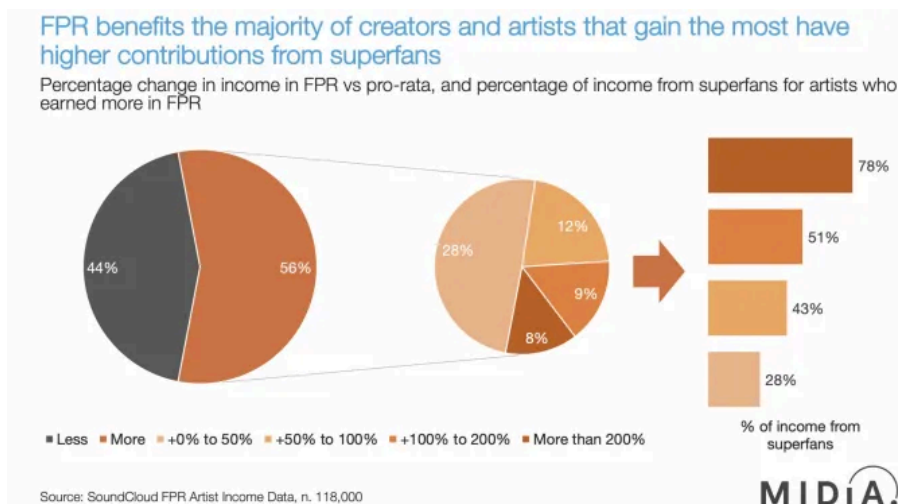


IMAGE CREDITS: [MIDiA](#)

Though SoundCloud isn't particularly popular for paid subscribers either, it hosts a ton of music — more than 300 million tracks from 30 million artists. Because SoundCloud hosts so many independent musicians, it's been easier to study how FPR works in practice.

In one of the first studies of FPR in action, entertainment research firm MIDiA analyzed FPR data from 118,000 SoundCloud musicians, finding that 56% of artists earned more under FPR than pro-rata models; but those who earned less under FPR were often larger artists with over 100,000 listeners.

MIDiA also made the interesting observation that smaller artists get larger payouts when they have “superfans,” or listeners whose streams contribute more than ten cents a month. The report also found that FPR helps the longtail of musicians move up into higher payout brackets — SoundCloud saw a 9.2% increase in artists who earned over \$1,000 from streaming payouts between April 2021 and February 2022.

For user-driven payout models to have a significant industry effect, larger players like Spotify or Apple Music need to adopt the model and get record labels on board, which is no small task. But at the very least, SoundCloud's deal with WMG is promising news.

[SoundCloud acquires Musiio, an AI music curator, to improve discovery](#)

[Spotify adds more artists to its Blend tool, allows fans to buy merch via the feature](#)

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Podcasters, get ready to find out how many followers you have on Apple Podcasts

Amanda Silberling — 5:00 AM PDT · March 22, 2022

Apple Podcasts is [rolling out](#) new features to incentivize podcasters to offer [paid subscriptions](#) to listeners on the app. One of those features will — for better or for worse — reveal to podcasters in their private analytics dashboard how many people follow them on Apple Podcasts. Get ready for an ego check!

For whatever reason, follower counts haven't been visible to creators, though the Apple Podcasts Connect page has shown stats about how many listeners you have, how long people listen before dropping off and how different episodes perform compared to one another.

Some podcasters might notice that their stats on Apple Podcasts Connect are lower than expected, though. The [majority of U.S. podcast listeners use Spotify](#), so these analytics, which only show Apple

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Google denies AI search features are killing website traffic

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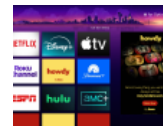


Substack rival Ghost connects to the open social web with its latest public release

Sarah Perez - 2 days ago

Podcasts listenership, don't offer creators a holistic picture of their show's performance (however, the drop-off rate can be useful information, since that data point isn't available on distribution platforms like Libsyn).

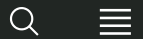
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Aisha Malik - 2 days ago

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taking a revenue cut, and after two years after its launch, it will take 5%. Other podcasters may choose to monetize their shows in a different way entirely by creating fan memberships on platforms like Patreon, which may include access to private Discord servers that help cultivate a community around a show, as opposed to just offering platform-specific bonus content.

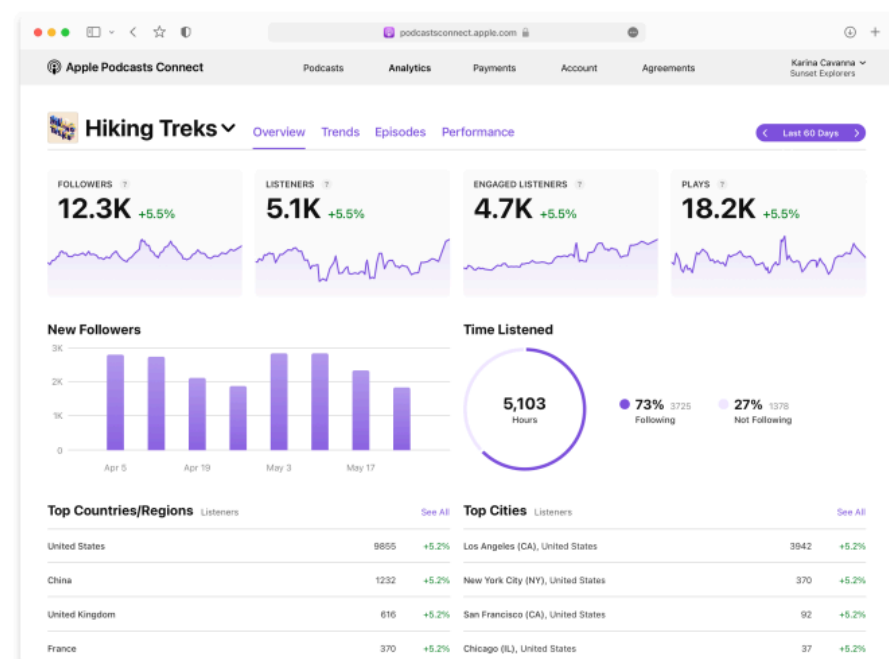


IMAGE CREDITS: APPLE PODCASTS

But Apple’s advantage is that its app comes pre-downloaded on your iPhone, so newer podcast listeners may find it easier to subscribe to a show on an app they already have. Apple is so eager to get a chunk of podcasters’ revenue that it’s launching Jump Start, a program that offers podcasters direct guidance from the Apple Podcasts team to develop their subscription offerings. But this guidance is only available to members of the Apple Podcasters Program — people who have already opted into selling a subscription on Apple Podcasts by paying a \$19.99 annual fee.

A few more minor updates for those enrolled in the program: Now, you can upload .mp3 files as subscriber-only audio (previously, you could only upload .wav and .flac), and you can customize the subscription banner that appears on your show.

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All updates will roll out today, except for that tantalizing follower count, which will appear on creators' Apple Podcasts Connect dashboards next month.

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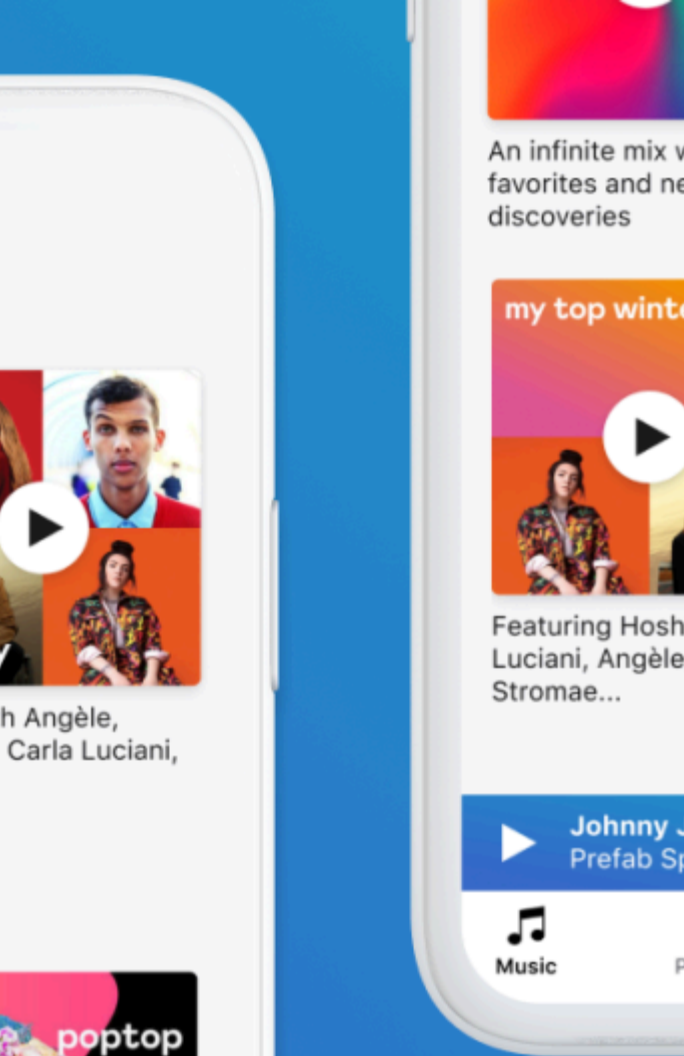
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Music streamer Deezer is going public via SPAC at a \$1.1B valuation

Amanda Silberling — 2:33 PM PDT · April 18, 2022

A European music streamer, Deezer is going public via a [SPAC deal](#), valuing the Spotify competitor at \$1.1 billion. Deezer will merge with the “blank-check” company [I2PO](#), which is headed by former WarnerMedia executive Iris Knobloch.

IMAGE CREDITS: DEEZER

Founded in 2007, the company previously [tried to IPO](#) in 2015, only to reverse course and raise [Series E](#) and Series F rounds in 2016 and 2018. Around the time of its first attempt at an IPO, investors were worried about the profitability of music streaming, since Pandora had just [lost nearly \\$86 million](#) in one quarter.

Since then, highly resourced streamers like Spotify, Amazon and Apple have only continued to grow, renewing market interest in music. But Deezer has also struggled to compete with these behemoths — as of Q2 2021, Deezer [only held 2%](#) of the global streaming music subscription market, though it's more popular abroad than in the U.S. In France and

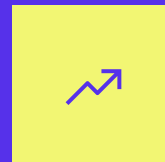
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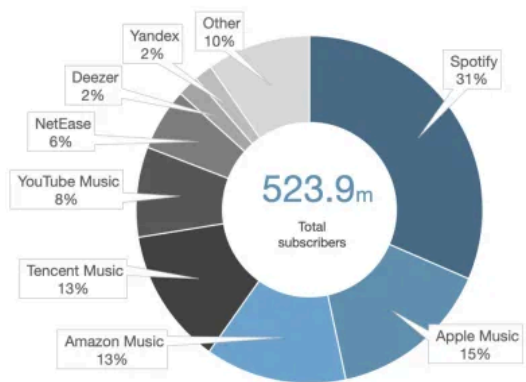


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Brazil, the company [holds 29% and 17%](#) of the market share respectively.

Global streaming music subscription market, Q2 2021

Global streaming music subscription market, Q2 2021, global



Source: MIDiA Research Music Subscriber Market Share Model 11/21

MIDiA.

IMAGE CREDITS: MIDiA

According to the Wall Street Journal, Deezer [isn't making money](#) yet, but per this deal, it hopes to be profitable by 2025. Deezer currently has 9.6 million subscribers, offers 90 million streaming songs plus podcasts and audiobooks, and generated €400 million in revenue last year. Spotify, for comparison, has [180 million paid subscribers](#) and a total of 406 million monthly active users including its free tier. But Deezer offers HiFi audio, while Spotify still hasn't [made that leap](#). Deezer has also expressed interest in a more [musician-friendly payment model](#), while Spotify has been [criticized by artists](#) for offering low streaming payouts.

“Today marks an important milestone in Deezer’s history as we embark on a journey to become a publicly traded company on Euronext Paris,” said Jeronimo Folgueira, Deezer’s CEO, in a statement. “We are uniquely positioned on the growing music streaming industry, with a very competitive product, a clear strategy and an experienced and renewed management team to seize this opportunity and create substantial shareholder value.”

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Unpacking music streaming economics through the lens of Deezer's SPAC



The Exchange procured Deezer's release and investor presentation. Let's parse the data and see what the economics of a smaller music streaming business look like today.



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